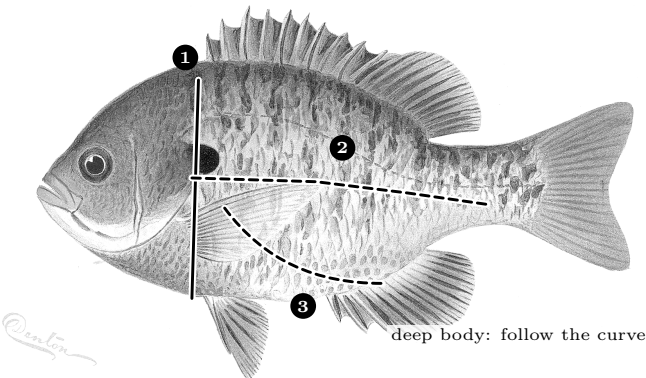


Cooking Bluegill

Lepomis macrochirus — in the kitchen

The fish most people learn to clean on



Blue Gill Sun Fish — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Verdict	Sweet, delicate and white. Slightly softer than perch but every bit as good, and there are usually a lot more of them.
Texture	Fine and tender. It will fall apart if you handle it roughly in the pan — that is the only difficulty.
Best size	8 in and up to fillet. Below that, pan-dress. A 9 in bluegill is a trophy and a superb meal.
Yield	Poor — about 22%. The deep body shape means a lot of fish becomes a little fillet. Budget three or four fish per person.
Ethics	June bed fish are the easiest to catch and the ones the population needs. Take a meal, not a cooler. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i>
Freezing	Freeze in a block of water rather than dry — delicate flesh burns quickly in a freezer.

Filleting a deep-bodied fish

1. **Cut behind the gill plate**, following the curve of the gill cover down and around, to the backbone.
2. **Run the blade along the backbone** to the tail. On a deep-bodied fish the backbone sits high — roughly halfway up — so aim higher than feels right.
3. **Take the ribs** with a shallow arc, or cut the whole belly section away.
4. **Skin it** from the tail end. Bluegill skin releases easily.
5. **Or pan-dress:** scale it with the back of a knife against the grain, gut it, cut the head off behind the gills, trim the fins. Cook whole. For fish under about 8 in this is both faster and gives more food.

Bones and what to watch for

Spines	The dorsal spines are sharp. Trim the whole spiny dorsal off first with kitchen shears — it makes the rest safer and quicker.
Rib cage	Fine and easy to lift out.
No pin bones	A bluegill fillet is clean once the ribs are out.
Pan-dressed	The whole skeleton lifts out in one piece after cooking. Teach a child to do this and they will eat fish for life.

Cooking it

Method	How
Cornmeal-fried	Buttermilk, then fine cornmeal with salt and cayenne. Hot oil, two minutes a side. The classic and still the best.
Whole and crisp	Pan-dressed, scored twice on each side, floured, shallow-fried until crisp. Eat everything except the spine.
Bluegill cakes	For a big catch of small fish. Poach the fillets, flake, bind with egg, breadcrumbs, spring onion and mustard. Fry as patties. This is what to do with a hundred small ones.

The teaching fish

Bluegill is the right fish to learn knife work on: there are lots of them, they are cheap to ruin, and the anatomy is simple and obvious. Let a teenager fillet six badly before you correct anything. The seventh will be fine, and they will have learnt more than any amount of watching.

Wisconsin safe-eating guidance. For bluegill, crappie, yellow perch, sunfish, rock bass and bullhead: **one serving per week** for women under 50 and children under 15; **unrestricted** for women over 50 and men. This is the statewide advice for inland waters, from the DNR and DHS *Choose Wisely* guide. Over 150 Wisconsin waters carry stricter site-specific advice — check the current booklet or the DNR’s Eat Your Catch query tool for these lakes before you make a habit of it.

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